

CCNA 200-301 V2.0

34 Exam Strategy

Part VI — Sitting the Exam

LECTURER

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Where this chapter sits

Part I	Foundations	chapters 1–7
Part II	Switching and Network Access	chapters 8–14
Part III	IP Routing	chapters 15–19
Part IV	Network Services and Security	chapters 20–26
Part V	Wireless, Virtualisation and Operations	chapters 27–32
Part VI	Sitting the Exam	chapters 33–34

What you will be able to do

- **Recognise** each question type and know what it demands of you.
- **Budget** 120 minutes across a paper you cannot navigate backwards through.
- **Read** a question for its qualifiers before answering it.
- **Plan** the final month of revision against the verb distribution rather than against the chapter list.

Before we start

The rest of the book. This chapter assumes you have worked the labs; it is about delivering what you know inside two hours.

Vocabulary for this chapter

multiple choice

drag and drop

simlet

simulation

qualifier

time budget

no back-navigation

Each is defined where it first matters — not here.

What this chapter can and cannot tell you

The 120-minute duration and the domain weights come from Cisco's published exam description and are reliable.

Cisco does not publish the number of questions, and does not publish a passing score for this exam. Scores are scaled, and the cut score can change between forms. Anyone quoting you an exact question count or an exact percentage is repeating hearsay, and this book will not add to it.

What follows is therefore built on the facts Cisco does publish plus the arithmetic of a fixed two hours. Before you book, work through Cisco's own free exam tutorial so that the interface is not new on the day, and re-read the current exam policies — they change, and this chapter does not update itself.

You cannot go back

Cisco's exam engine does not let you return to a question once you have moved past it. There is no review screen, no flag-for-later, no second pass.

Every habit you built sitting university papers — skim first, do the easy ones, come back to the hard ones — is unavailable. Sitting this exam as though it were a normal paper is the most expensive mistake available to you, and it is entirely avoidable.

Three consequences follow, and they are the whole of exam strategy here:

- **Every question must be answered when you meet it.** Never leave one blank intending to return. You cannot.
- **Never leave one blank at all.** There is no negative marking. An educated guess is worth strictly more than a blank.
- **A question you dwell on is stealing time from questions you have not seen yet,** and you have no way to know what they are worth.

The AI-evaluation questions are not confined to domain 5

This is what the blueprint actually asks for

Cisco's exam description says you "may be required to evaluate output and recommendations from agentic AI and digital network assistants to support network operations and troubleshooting activities."

Read that as: a question anywhere in the paper may show you an assistant's suggested diagnosis or configuration and ask whether it is right. The skill is the one from Chapter 32 — a plausible, fluent, confidently wrong answer is the characteristic failure — combined with the actual technical knowledge to spot it. Treat such output exactly as you would a suggestion from a colleague you do not know: check it against what the exhibit shows.

Simulations: do them properly when you meet them

Because you cannot come back, a simulation cannot be deferred. Skimping on it to save time is a false economy — it is worth several ordinary questions.

- **Read the whole task first.** All of it. Then plan the commands before typing any.
- **Configure exactly what is asked and nothing else.** Extra work risks breaking a check.
- **Verify with `show` before you leave.** The habit from every chapter of this book applies here and takes thirty seconds.
- **Save the configuration if the task says to** — and consider it even when it does not. `copy running-config startup-config` costs nothing (Chapter 31 makes the same point about `save_when`).
- **If you cannot complete it, complete part of it.** A partially configured task scores more than an untouched one.

Answer the question that was asked

The commonest self-inflicted error is answering a slightly different, more interesting question — explaining the cause when asked for the next diagnostic step, or giving the best long-term design when asked what restores service now.

Before selecting, re-read the interrogative. It takes two seconds.

Subnetting must be automatic, not calculable

It appears inside other questions — an ACL wildcard, a summary route, whether two addresses are on the same subnet — where it is not the point of the question but stands between you and the answer.

If you are working it out on paper, it is costing you thirty seconds every time it appears. Drill it until the common masks are recall rather than arithmetic. Appendix app:subnetting exists for this.

On the day



Common pitfalls

- **Planning to come back to it.** You cannot.
- **Leaving anything blank.** No negative marking.
- **Reading the exhibit before the question.**
- **Missing “choose two”.**
- **Rushing a simulation** to protect time for questions you have not seen.
- **Not verifying a simulation** with a `show` command.
- **Revising by re-reading** when 55% of the paper is hands-on.

Common pitfalls (continued)

- **Learning the interface on the day.** Take the tutorial.
- **Trusting a quoted pass mark or question count.** Cisco publishes neither.

A candidate who knew the material and ran out of time.

A candidate rebuilds every lab in this book, works every Break & Fix, and scores well on practice tests. They fail. Their time log, reconstructed afterwards, looks like this.

A candidate who knew the material and ran out of time.

What would you check first — and what do you expect to see?

time log

Reconstructed#

00:00 - 00:34	First 18 questions. Comfortable, roughly 110 sec each.
00:34 - 00:48	One OSPF question. Recognised it, wanted to be sure, worked the DR election through on the whiteboard.
00:48 - 01:12	Next 12 questions, hurrying now, roughly 120 sec each.
01:12 - 01:31	First simulation. Completed, not verified.
01:31 - 01:52	Next 9 questions. Guessing on several.
01:52 - 02:00	Second simulation reached with 8 minutes left. Partially configured. Not saved.

What is the fault — and what does this output rule out?

Why it is doing that

Diagnosis. The knowledge was there. Three decisions spent it.

The 14 minutes at 00:34. One question, already answered correctly in their head, verified at the cost of roughly twelve other questions' worth of time. The instinct — be certain before committing, because you cannot come back — is understandable and exactly backwards: you cannot come back, so the cost of over-investing is unrecoverable too.

The hurrying that followed. Every question from 00:48 onward was answered under self-inflicted pressure created fourteen minutes earlier. Time lost early is not repaid; it is paid for by everything after it.

Why it is doing that

The second simulation. Reached with eight minutes left because of the first two decisions, and worth several times an ordinary question. Partially configured and not saved — so much of the work that was done scored nothing.

And the lesson

What should have happened. At 00:44 — ten minutes into that OSPF question — the correct move was to select the best answer available and go. It was probably right. Even if it was wrong, one mark is cheaper than twelve.

The rule to take in with you. No single question is worth more than about ninety seconds. Not the one you nearly know, not the one you are annoyed by, not the one you could definitely get with a little longer. Set that limit before you sit down, because you will not set it fairly at 00:40 with a half-solved problem in front of you.

A full-length timed rehearsal

Why this is the last lab in the book. You have practised the material. You have not practised the *conditions* — two hours, no going back, no notes, no pausing. Those are a separate skill and they are what the Break & Fix above is about.

1. Assemble a paper: about 90 questions from the review sections of this book, weighted to the domain percentages — roughly a quarter each from Parts I and II, a fifth each from Parts III and IV, a tenth from Part V.
2. Add two configuration tasks from the labs, to stand in for simulations.
3. **Set the rules and keep them.** 120 minutes. No notes. **No returning to a previous question** — cover them, or have someone else administer it. This constraint is the entire point of the exercise.
4. Sit it in one block, at the time of day you have booked the real exam.
5. Record a timestamp every ten questions. Do not analyse during.

A full-length timed rehearsal (continued)

6. **Afterwards, mark the timing before you mark the answers.** Find every question that took more than 90 seconds and count what they cost collectively. This number is usually a surprise.
7. Now mark the answers. Separate the wrong ones into *did not know* and *knew but misread or rushed*. They need completely different remedies, and the second pile is usually bigger than expected.
8. For every “did not know”, find the chapter and redo its lab — not its summary.
9. **Repeat two weeks later** with a different selection. Compare the timing profile, not just the score. Improvement in timing is the better predictor.

CHECKPOINT 1 of 6

What is the single most important structural fact about the exam interface, and name three habits it invalidates?

Discuss · then advance

Checkpoint 1 of 6

What is the single most important structural fact about the exam interface, and name three habits it invalidates?

You cannot return to a previous question. It invalidates skimming the paper first, leaving hard questions to come back to, and flagging anything for review.

CHECKPOINT 2 of 6

How long should a standard question take, and what do you do at the limit?

Discuss · then advance

Checkpoint 2 of 6

How long should a standard question take, and what do you do at the limit?

60 to 75 seconds. At 90 seconds, eliminate what you can, choose the best remaining option, and move on — the question you have not seen yet may be one you would answer in twenty seconds.

CHECKPOINT 3 of 6

Why can a simulation not be deferred, and what four things should you do in one?

Discuss · then advance

Checkpoint 3 of 6

Why can a simulation not be deferred, and what four things should you do in one?

Because you cannot come back to it, so a deferred simulation is an abandoned one. Read the whole task first; plan before typing; configure only what is asked; verify with a `show` command — and save if the task says to.

CHECKPOINT 4 of 6

Read the exhibit or the question first? Why?

Discuss · then advance

Checkpoint 4 of 6

Read the exhibit or the question first? Why?

The **question** first. Otherwise you study an entire configuration or topology to answer something about one line of it.

CHECKPOINT 5 of 6

Which topics should be revised last, and why?

Discuss · then advance

Checkpoint 5 of 6

Which topics should be revised last, and why?

The *describe* topics — wireless principles, virtualisation, VPNs, management approaches, AI — because they are recall-heavy and recall decays fastest. Configuration skill does not.

CHECKPOINT 6 of 6

What does Cisco publish about this exam, and what does it not?

Discuss · then advance

Checkpoint 6 of 6

What does Cisco publish about this exam, and what does it not?

Cisco publishes the 120-minute duration, the five domains and their weights, and the 29 topics with their wording. It does **not** publish the number of questions or the passing score.

What to take away

- **You cannot return to a question.** Answer everything when you meet it, never leave a blank, and never plan to come back.
- Roughly 60–75 seconds per standard question; hard stop at 90. Budget 10–15 minutes for each simulation.
- No single question is worth more than ninety seconds. Time lost early is never repaid.
- Question before exhibit. Watch for qualifiers, negatives and the required count.
- In a simulation: read it all, plan, configure only what is asked, verify with [show](#), save. Partial completion beats none.

What to take away (continued)

- v2.0 may ask you to evaluate an AI assistant's output anywhere in the paper, not only in domain 5.
- Revise against the verbs: 55% hands-on, so spend the time at a command line. Leave the *describe* topics until last, and make subnetting automatic.
- Cisco publishes 120 minutes and the domain weights. It does not publish the question count or the pass mark. Take the official tutorial before the day.

Where we got to

- **You cannot return to a question.** Answer everything when you meet it, never leave a blank, and never plan to come back.
- Roughly 60–75 seconds per standard question; hard stop at 90. Budget 10–15 minutes for each simulation.
- No single question is worth more than ninety seconds. Time lost early is never repaid.
- Question before exhibit. Watch for qualifiers, negatives and the required count.

END OF THE COURSE

34 chapters · all 29 blueprint topics · 32 labs